

3.3 Starting Stewards and Resource Tiles

Each player places their Steward's matching starting Resource Tile for free on an empty map space with matching terrain. This ignores normal placement costs and adjacency requirements. Then place that player's Steward Token on that tile.

Steward	Starting Terrain	Starting Resource Tile
Vanguard	Woodland	Forest
Knight	Arable Land	Farm
Sentinel	Mountains	Mine
Ranger	Heaths	Wildlands
Warden	Ruins	Dig Site
Quartermaster	Any valid terrain	Any unused valid Resource Tile type

UNIQUE STEWARDS

Each named Steward is unique. The Quartermaster chooses any valid starting terrain and Resource Tile type not already used during setup.

3.4 Balanced Encounter Pool Setup

The standard game uses a balanced Encounter pool. Build the pool from separate Boon, Burden, and Arrival decks before dealing player hands and the Encounter Deck.

Players	Boons in Game Pool	Burdens in Game Pool	Arrivals in Game Pool	Standard Encounter Pool	Golden Boon	Hidden Cards per Player	Standard Cards to Encounter Deck
1	5	5	5	15	+1	10	5
2	10	10	10	30	+1	10 each	10
3	15	15	15	45	+1	10 each	15
4	20	20	20	60	+1	10 each	20

1. Shuffle the Boon deck and deal 5 Boons per player into the game pool.
2. Shuffle the Burden deck and deal 5 Burdens per player into the game pool.
3. Shuffle the Arrival deck and deal 5 Arrivals per player into the game pool.
4. Return unused standard Encounter Cards to the box face-down without revealing them.
5. Shuffle the game pool.
6. Deal 10 hidden Encounter Cards to each player.
7. Deal 5 standard Encounter Cards per player to the Encounter Deck on the Stewards Board.
8. Add exactly 1 random Golden Boon to the Encounter Deck and shuffle it.
9. Return all unused Golden Boons to the box.

NOTE

Golden Boons are handled separately and are never dealt to player hands.

3.5 Hidden Encounter Cards

In the standard 1-4 player game, player hands are hidden. Players should not discuss specific card names, exact effects, or precise seeding plans until those cards are revealed. General strategic discussion is allowed, but hidden-hand certainty should be preserved.

NOTE

Open-hand play is not part of the standard 1-4 player game. For larger groups, use the Council Variant in Section 17.